

Career Planning and Management

Module 3 — Exam Ready Notes
BCA / CS Students

Contents

1	Choosing Your Career	2
1.1	Definition	2
1.2	Key Steps in Career Selection	2
1.3	Factors Influencing Career Choice	2
1.4	Common Career Paths for CS/BCA Graduates	2
1.5	Exam Tips	2
2	Researching and Clarifying Company Preferences	3
2.1	Definition	3
2.2	Key Research Areas	3
2.3	Sources for Company Research	3
2.4	Clarifying Your Own Preferences	3
3	Creating a Company Profile	4
3.1	Definition	4
3.2	Components of a Company Profile	4
3.3	Why Create a Company Profile?	4
3.4	Exam Tips	4
4	Making Contact with Companies	5
4.1	Methods of Contact	5
4.2	Writing a Cold Email	5
4.3	LinkedIn Profile Tips for Contact	5
4.4	Exam Tips	5
5	Understanding Company Functions	6
5.1	Definition	6
5.2	Core Functions of a Company	6
5.3	IT/Tech Department Structure (Relevant for CS/BCA)	6
5.4	Why This Matters for Job Seekers	6
6	Developing the Resume	7
6.1	Definition	7
6.2	Types of Resume Formats	7
6.3	Standard Sections of a Resume	7
6.4	Resume Writing Rules	7
6.5	ATS (Applicant Tracking System)	7
6.6	Common Mistakes to Avoid	8
6.7	Exam Tips	8

7	Preparing Yourself for Interview	9
7.1	Types of Interviews	9
7.2	Stages of a Typical Campus / Company Interview Process	9
7.3	Preparing for Technical Interviews (CS/BCA Focus)	9
7.4	Preparing for HR Interviews	9
7.5	Interview Do's and Don'ts	10
7.6	Non-Verbal Communication Tips	10
7.7	Post-Interview Steps	10
7.8	Exam Tips	10
	Quick Revision Summary	11

Choosing Your Career

Definition

Career choice is the process of identifying a profession that aligns with your skills, interests, values, and long-term goals.

Key Steps in Career Selection

1. **Self-Assessment** — Identify your strengths, weaknesses, interests, and personality traits.
2. **Career Exploration** — Research available fields, roles, and growth prospects.
3. **Goal Setting** — Define short-term (1–2 years) and long-term (5+ years) career goals.
4. **Decision Making** — Narrow down options based on fit, scope, and opportunity.
5. **Action Plan** — Develop a roadmap with milestones to reach your chosen career.

Factors Influencing Career Choice

- Personal interests and hobbies
- Academic background and skills
- Family expectations and financial needs
- Market demand and job availability
- Location preferences
- Work-life balance requirements

Common Career Paths for CS/BCA Graduates

Domain	Typical Roles
Software Development	Software Engineer, Full Stack Developer, Backend Developer
Data & AI	Data Analyst, ML Engineer, Business Intelligence Analyst
Infrastructure	System Administrator, Cloud Engineer, DevOps Engineer
Management	IT Project Manager, Product Manager, Business Analyst
Security	Cybersecurity Analyst, Ethical Hacker, Security Consultant

Exam Tips

- Know the difference between a *job* (short-term role) and a *career* (long-term progression).
- Self-assessment tools: SWOT analysis, Holland Code (RIASEC), Myers-Briggs.

Researching and Clarifying Company Preferences

Definition

Before applying, candidates must research potential employers to understand what type of company suits their goals and working style.

Key Research Areas

1. **Industry Type** — IT services, product company, startup, MNC, government PSU.
2. **Company Culture** — Work environment, values, diversity, employee satisfaction.
3. **Growth Opportunities** — Promotion paths, training programs, lateral movements.
4. **Compensation** — Salary range, bonuses, ESOPs, benefits package.
5. **Work Location** — On-site, remote, hybrid; preferred city or country.
6. **Company Size** — Startup vs. mid-size vs. large enterprise (different experiences).

Sources for Company Research

- Official company website and annual reports
- LinkedIn company page
- Glassdoor and AmbitionBox reviews
- News articles and press releases
- Alumni networks and referrals

Clarifying Your Own Preferences

Ask yourself:

- Do I prefer a structured corporate environment or a flexible startup?
- Is salary my top priority, or is learning and growth more important?
- Am I comfortable with frequent travel or relocation?
- Do I want to work in a technical role or move into management?

Creating a Company Profile

Definition

A company profile is a structured summary of an organization's key details compiled by a job-seeker during their research phase.

Components of a Company Profile

Component	Details to Include
Basic Information	Company name, founded year, headquarters, industry
Products/Services	Core offerings, technology stack used
Size & Reach	Number of employees, offices, global presence
Financials	Revenue, recent funding, growth rate
Culture & Values	Mission statement, work culture, awards
Hiring Process	Typical interview stages, skills tested
Key Contacts	HR contact, recruiter names, LinkedIn profiles

Why Create a Company Profile?

- Helps tailor your resume and cover letter to the company.
- Prepares you for the “Why do you want to work here?” interview question.
- Helps you evaluate an offer intelligently once received.
- Demonstrates genuine interest and professionalism.

Exam Tips

- A company profile is *built by the candidate* for their own reference — it is not a company's official document.
- Always update your profile before every interview round.

Making Contact with Companies

Methods of Contact

1. **Online Job Portals** — Apply via Naukri, LinkedIn Jobs, Indeed, Internshala.
2. **Direct Email** — Send a cold email to the HR or hiring manager with your resume.
3. **LinkedIn Outreach** — Connect with recruiters; send a short, professional InMail.
4. **Campus Placement Cell** — Work through your college's TPO (Training & Placement Officer).
5. **Networking Events** — Attend hackathons, tech fairs, alumni meets, and conferences.
6. **Referrals** — Ask a known employee to refer you internally.
7. **Walk-in Interviews** — Some companies conduct open drives; check announcements.

Writing a Cold Email

Structure:

- **Subject:** Application for [Role] — [Your Name]
- **Opening:** Introduce yourself briefly (name, qualification, college).
- **Body:** Mention why you are interested in the company; highlight 2–3 relevant skills.
- **Closing:** Request an opportunity for a call or interview; attach resume.
- **Tone:** Formal, concise (under 150 words), error-free.

LinkedIn Profile Tips for Contact

- Keep your headline updated: e.g., “BCA Student | Java Developer | Seeking 2025 Opportunities”
- Always personalize connection request messages.
- Follow target companies to get notified of openings.

Exam Tips

- Know the difference between *active job search* (applying directly) and *passive job search* (being discovered by recruiters).
- Networking accounts for more than 70% of job placements globally.

Understanding Company Functions

Definition

Understanding how a company is structured and what each department does helps you identify where you fit and how to navigate the organization after joining.

Core Functions of a Company

Function	Role in the Organization
Human Resources (HR)	Recruitment, training, payroll, employee relations
Finance & Accounts	Budgeting, financial reporting, taxation, auditing
Marketing	Branding, advertising, customer acquisition
Sales	Revenue generation, client management, business development
Operations	Day-to-day processes, supply chain, quality control
IT / Technology	Software development, infrastructure, data management
Legal & Compliance	Contracts, regulatory compliance, intellectual property
Research & Development	Innovation, new product development, prototyping

IT/Tech Department Structure (Relevant for CS/BCA)

- **Development Team** — Writes, tests, and maintains software.
- **QA/Testing Team** — Validates product quality before release.
- **DevOps/Infra Team** — Manages deployment pipelines and cloud infrastructure.
- **Product Management** — Defines product features and roadmaps.
- **Data/Analytics Team** — Handles data pipelines, reporting, and AI/ML models.

Why This Matters for Job Seekers

- Helps you apply for the right role in the right department.
- Helps you understand cross-functional collaboration during interviews.
- Useful when you ask the interviewer: “How does this team collaborate with other departments?”

Developing the Resume

Definition

A resume (also called a CV) is a formal document that summarizes your education, skills, experience, and achievements for a prospective employer.

Types of Resume Formats

Format	Best For	Structure
Chronological	Experienced candidates	Latest experience first
Functional	Career changers, freshers	Skills grouped by type
Combination	Mid-level professionals	Mix of skills + experience

Standard Sections of a Resume

1. **Contact Information** — Name, phone, email, LinkedIn, GitHub (for CS/BCA).
2. **Objective / Summary** — 2–3 line summary of your profile and goals.
3. **Education** — Degree, university, year, percentage/CGPA.
4. **Technical Skills** — Programming languages, tools, frameworks, databases.
5. **Projects** — Title, tech stack used, your role, outcome/impact.
6. **Internships / Work Experience** — Company, role, duration, key contributions.
7. **Certifications** — Online courses, professional certifications.
8. **Achievements / Awards** — Hackathons, academic ranks, competitions.
9. **Extra-Curricular Activities** — Leadership, sports, volunteering.

Resume Writing Rules

- **Length:** 1 page for freshers; max 2 pages for experienced.
- **Font:** Use clean fonts — Times New Roman, Arial, or Calibri at 10–12pt.
- **Tense:** Use past tense for previous work; present tense for current roles.
- **Action Verbs:** Start bullet points with verbs — Developed, Designed, Built, Analyzed, Led.
- **Quantify:** Add numbers where possible — “Reduced API response time by 30%”.
- **Tailor:** Customize for each job description; match keywords.
- **No Photo:** Avoid photos unless explicitly asked (varies by country).
- **Proofread:** Zero grammatical or spelling errors.

ATS (Applicant Tracking System)

Most large companies use ATS software to filter resumes before a human reads them.

- Use simple formatting — no tables, columns, or graphics (for ATS-targeted versions).
- Include keywords from the job description.
- Submit in PDF format unless the portal specifically asks for DOCX.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Using an unprofessional email address (e.g., coolboy99@gmail.com).
- Adding irrelevant personal info (height, weight, religion).
- Listing skills you cannot demonstrate in an interview.
- Using a generic objective statement copy-pasted from the internet.

Exam Tips

- Know all three resume formats and when to use each.
- Difference between Resume and CV: A resume is short (1–2 pages, job-focused); a CV is comprehensive (academic record, publications, used in research/academia).

Preparing Yourself for Interview

Types of Interviews

Type	Description
Telephonic/Video	Initial screening round; tests basic communication and fit
Technical Interview	Tests domain knowledge, coding, problem-solving
HR Interview	Tests personality, communication, cultural fit, compensation
Panel Interview	Multiple interviewers from different departments
Group Discussion (GD)	Tests teamwork, communication, and leadership
Aptitude/Written Test	Logical reasoning, quantitative, verbal ability

Stages of a Typical Campus / Company Interview Process

1. Online Aptitude Test
2. Technical Written / Coding Round
3. Technical Interview Round 1 (DSA, OOP, DBMS, OS, CN)
4. Technical Interview Round 2 (Projects, system design basics)
5. HR Interview (Personality, goals, salary negotiation)

Preparing for Technical Interviews (CS/BCA Focus)

- **Data Structures & Algorithms:** Arrays, Linked List, Stacks, Queues, Trees, Graphs, Sorting, Searching.
- **OOP Concepts:** Encapsulation, Inheritance, Polymorphism, Abstraction.
- **DBMS:** SQL queries, Normalization (1NF–3NF), ACID properties, Joins.
- **Operating Systems:** Process management, Scheduling, Memory management, Deadlock.
- **Computer Networks:** OSI model, TCP/IP, HTTP/HTTPS, DNS, IP addressing.
- **Projects:** Be ready to explain every line of your project; know the tech stack well.

Preparing for HR Interviews

Commonly Asked HR Questions:

1. Tell me about yourself.
2. What are your strengths and weaknesses?
3. Why do you want to join this company?
4. Where do you see yourself in 5 years?
5. Why should we hire you?
6. Are you comfortable with relocation/night shifts?
7. What is your salary expectation?

Tips for HR Round:

- Use the **STAR Method** for behavioral questions: **S**ituation, **T**ask, **A**ction, **R**esult.
- Be honest about gaps; never lie on your resume.

- Research the company before arriving — mention specific products or values.
- Prepare 2–3 questions to ask the interviewer (shows genuine interest).

Interview Do's and Don'ts

Do's	Don'ts
Arrive 10–15 minutes early Dress professionally Maintain eye contact Listen carefully before answering Be concise and structured Carry printed copies of your resume Thank the interviewer at the end	Do not arrive late Avoid casual or informal clothing Do not avoid eye contact Do not interrupt the interviewer Do not give very long, vague answers Do not carry only a soft copy Do not leave abruptly

Non-Verbal Communication Tips

- Sit upright; maintain confident but relaxed posture.
- Smile and nod appropriately — shows active listening.
- Avoid fidgeting, looking at your phone, or crossing arms.
- Speak clearly and at a moderate pace — do not rush.

Post-Interview Steps

1. Send a brief thank-you email within 24 hours.
2. Reflect on questions you found difficult — prepare better for next time.
3. Follow up politely if you do not hear back within the stated timeframe.

Exam Tips

- Know the STAR method with an example.
- Know the difference between structured, semi-structured, and unstructured interviews.
- Group Discussion (GD) evaluates: Communication, Knowledge, Leadership, Teamwork, Confidence.

Quick Revision Summary

Topic	Key Points to Remember
Choosing Career	Self-assessment → Exploration → Goal Setting → Action Plan
Company Research	Industry, culture, growth, salary, location, size
Company Profile	Candidate-made document; includes size, culture, hiring process
Making Contact	Portals, cold email, LinkedIn, referrals, campus TPO
Company Functions	HR, Finance, Marketing, Sales, IT, Legal, R&D
Resume	Chronological/Functional/Combination; 1 page for freshers; ATS-friendly
Interview Prep	STAR method; know DSA, OOP, DBMS, OS, CN; research company

All the best for your exams!